

Process Improvement Case Study

Reducing Orphaned Access & Offboarding Delays

Prepared by: Shraddha Sisodiya

Portfolio Sample — fictional enterprise IAM scenario; not affiliated with, based on, or representing any real company or client.

1. Background

At a mid-size enterprise organization, employee access provisioning, role changes, and offboarding were coordinated manually between HR, IT, and department managers. An internal security review found a growing number of orphaned access grants and a multi-day gap between an employee's last working day and full account deactivation. This case study analyzes the root cause and proposes an automated redesign of the JML process.

2. Current-State Process Map

Step	Activity	Owner	Pain Point
1	HR notifies IT of a new hire, role change, or termination via email	HR Operations	No standardized trigger; relies on manual email
2	IT manually provisions or modifies access based on the email request	IT / IAM Operations	Delays and inconsistent access outcomes
3	Manager is expected to inform IT of access no longer needed after a role change	Department Manager	Rarely done consistently; access accumulates
4	IT deactivates terminated employee accounts upon receiving notice	IT / IAM Operations	Notice often delayed by several days
5	Periodic access review catches remaining discrepancies	Compliance Team	Reactive; discrepancies found months later

3. Root Cause Analysis

Using a 5-Whys approach on the orphaned-access problem:

- 5. Why does orphaned access accumulate? → Access isn't revoked when an employee's role changes.
- 6. Why isn't it revoked? → There is no automated reconciliation between role change and access entitlements.
- 7. Why is there no reconciliation? → Access grants were never mapped to a defined RBAC model tied to job roles.

8. Why was RBAC never implemented? → Provisioning grew organically through ad hoc manual requests rather than a designed access model.
9. Why wasn't this revisited? → The issue was only visible through periodic audits, which are reactive rather than preventive.

Root cause: absence of a defined RBAC model and automated lifecycle triggers — not individual reviewer error.

4. Proposed Future-State Process

Step	Activity	Change from Current State
1	HRIS event automatically triggers the JML workflow	Removes manual email-based notification
2	System provisions or reconciles access against the RBAC model	Removes inconsistent manual provisioning
3	Non-standard access requests routed to manager attestation	Adds a controlled exception path instead of ad hoc grants
4	Termination event triggers same-day automated deactivation	Removes multi-day exposure window
5	Dashboard tracks pending/overdue JML events in real time	Shifts compliance from reactive audit to proactive monitoring

5. Estimated Impact

Metric	Current State	Target State	Est. Improvement
New-hire provisioning time	~3 days	Under 4 hours	≈ 90% faster
Offboarding deactivation time	Up to several days	Within 4 hours	≈ 85% faster
Orphaned access instances (per audit cycle)	Baseline	Reduced via automated reconciliation	Significant reduction
SoD conflicts flagged proactively vs. found in audit	Mostly audit-discovered	Flagged at request time	Shift to preventive control

Note: figures above are illustrative estimates for this fictional scenario, modeled on typical outcomes of RBAC-based JML automation.

6. Recommendation

Prioritize automated termination-triggered deactivation first, since it closes the highest-risk security exposure window with the least implementation complexity. RBAC-based provisioning and role-change reconciliation can follow in a second phase once the role-to-access mapping is finalized with department stakeholders.

7. What This Demonstrates

- Ability to translate an identity lifecycle risk into a structured BRD with clear, testable requirements.
- Use of root-cause analysis (5-Whys) to identify a systemic control gap rather than individual error.

- Comfort quantifying security and compliance impact, and sequencing a phased, risk-prioritized rollout.
- Applied understanding of core IAM concepts — RBAC, SoD, provisioning/deprovisioning — translated into business requirements.